

In 2050, Can English Retain Its Position as the Global Lingua Franca?

Zhihu · 2026-03-08

As we analysed in the series on the capitalist world-system (The Rise and Fall of the Capitalist World-System (I): The Three Stages in the Evolution of the Mode of Production of the Capitalist World-System), the capitalist production of today's world has already crossed national borders and is organised at the global level. The globalised organisation of economic production necessarily means a great increase in transnational, cross-cultural communication between people. Just as capitalism's unification of the national market drove the spread of a national common language, so capitalism's organisation of trade and production at the global level drives the spread of an international common language.

After the Second World War, American capital led the process of capital globalisation, and the American government in effect performed the function of a world government pushing the transnationalisation of industrial capital — hence English became the lingua franca of international communication spread across the globe. Only after the war, however, did English become a foreign language truly widely taught in basic education, and an international lingua franca used not only by the global elite but by the broad working masses as well. English became the main language of transnational communication among the world's masses — especially the urban proletariat and petty bourgeoisie — as can be seen from the travel videos on social media such as YouTube and Xiaohongshu. Since the 1990s, in multinational corporations, English has gradually become the main language of internal transnational communication; the media have reported on this a great deal^{[1][2][3]}.

But as China and other countries rise and America gradually loses its position of global hegemony, as the world moves toward multipolarity (see: How Many Poles in a Multipolar World? A Look Ahead to 2050), will English lose its position as the global lingua franca? I have made some remarks on this question in earlier answers; in this article I intend to analyse it systematically.

I. The English-Speaking Population in 2050

According to Kachru's model of the Three Circles of English, the countries where English is the mother tongue of the majority form the inner circle; the countries once colonised by Britain or America form the outer circle; and the countries that learn English as a foreign language form the

expanding circle. Let us now analyse these groups of countries and see what their English-speaking populations will be in 2050.

(1) The Inner Circle

The chart below shows the population data of the inner-circle countries. Before 2050, nothing can weaken English's dominant position in these countries. Although heavy immigration reduces the number of native English speakers, half of the children of immigrants adopt English as their sole mother tongue by the second generation, or as one of their two mother tongues.

Thanks to continuous immigration, the population of the inner-circle countries will increase slightly by 2050, reaching about 540 million.

Country	Current population (millions)	2050 population (millions)
United States	341.8	370
United Kingdom	69.3	75.5
Canada	41.5	45.6
Australia	28.3	34.3
New Zealand	5.34	6
Ireland	5.3	5.7
Barbados	0.28	0.28
Bahamas	0.4	0.4
Jamaica	2.84	2.45
Total	495.06	540.23

(2) The Outer Circle

The outer-circle countries were once colonised by Britain or America, which left behind a whole set of English institutions and an English educational system; some even have a certain proportion of native English speakers. These countries generally make English one of their official languages or working languages, and English-medium teaching exists to varying degrees in their educational systems.

Some outer-circle countries once launched movements to promote indigenous languages — Tanzania, India, Bangladesh, and others. But in recent years, under the influence of economic globalisation, the demand in these societies — especially among parents — for English as the language of instruction

has risen so much that they have had to reintroduce English-medium teaching in public schools^{[4][5]} (see also: Will India Abandon English, with Hindi Taking Its Place?).

The chart below shows the English-speaking population data of these countries. Since English teaching in these countries is spreading widely, the share of English speakers is expected to rise universally by 2050. I have adopted relatively conservative estimates in compiling the 2050 shares. These outer-circle countries will have a total population of 3.44 billion in 2050, of which the English-speaking population is expected to reach 1.365 billion.

说明：人口单位是百万。当前英语普及率统计口径各国不同，有些国家没有按照熟练使用的标准，但至少满足基本交流要求，作者针对部分国家的数据做了一些降低的调整。

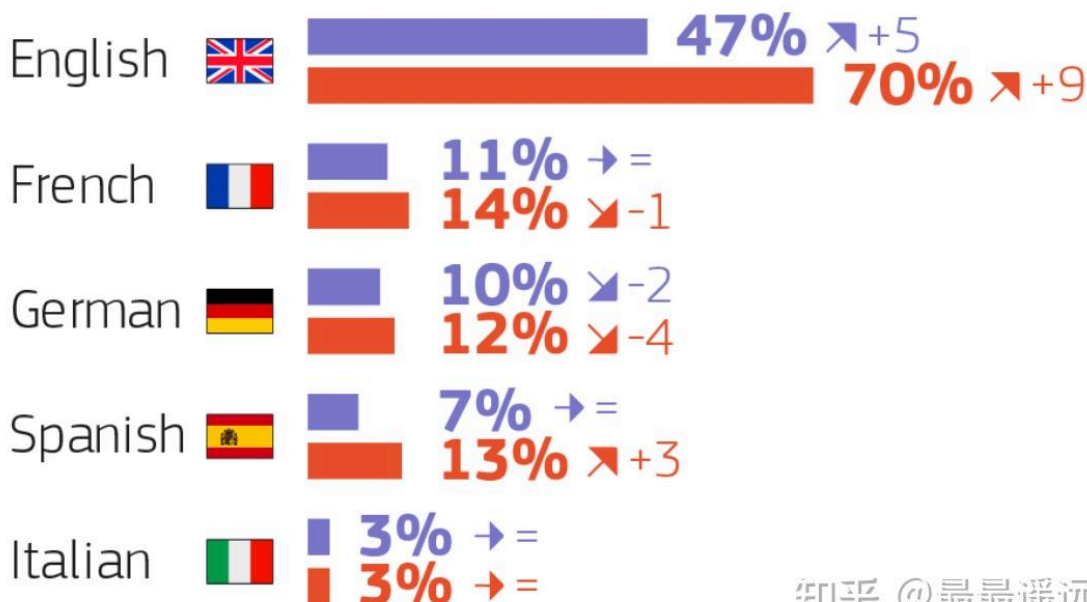
国家	人口（百万）	2050年人口（预计）	英语人口比例（当前值）	英语人口（当前）	英语人口（2050，不考虑英语普及率提高）	英语人口比例（2050，保守预测值）	英语人口（2050，考虑英语普及率提高）	英语母语人口比例	英语母语人口（当前）	小学教学语言中英语地位	初中教学语言中英语地位	高中教学语言中英语地位	高等教育教学语言中英语地位
India	1470	1668	10.60%	155.82	176.808	25%	417	0.02%	0.29	23%教学语言	20%教学语言	34%教学语言	49%教学语言
Nigeria	240	360	60.64%	145.536	218.304	70%	252	9.70%	23.28	100%教学语言	100%教学语言	100%教学语言	100%教学语言
Philippines	115.8	134	47.00%	54.426	62.98	70%	93.8	0.04%	0.05	3年级后英语作为STEM课程教学语言	英语作为STEM课程教学语言	英语作为STEM课程教学语言	主要教学语言
Singapore	6.1	6.1	74.21%	4.52681	4.52681	80%	4.88	48.25%	2.94	主要教学语言	主要教学语言	主要教学语言	主要教学语言
Pakistan	257	371	48.91%	125.6987	181.4561	60%	222.6	0.00%	0.00	私校（35%学生）主要教学语言	英语作为STEM课程教学语言	英语作为STEM课程教学语言	英语作为STEM课程教学语言
Bangladesh	173.5	214	6.53%	11.32955	13.9742	15%	32.1	0.43%	0.75	私校（24%学生）教学语言之一，占比不详	私校（90%学生）主要教学语言	私校（90%学生）主要教学语言	公校英语作为STEM课程的主要教学语言，私校（60%学生）英语作为主要教学语言
Kenya	54	83	50.00%	27	41.5	60%	49.8	0.00%	0.00	3年级后英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言
Tanzania	71.4	129	10.00%	7.14	12.9	20%	25.8	0.67%	0.48	政府在家长压力下开始推广英语教学的学校	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言
Malaysia	34.1	41.8	57.34%	19.55294	23.96812	70%	29.26	1.40%	0.48				私校（42%的学生）和顶级学校均以英语作为主要教学语言
Ghana	35	52.5	67.19%	23.5165	35.27475	80%	42	0.00%	0.00	3年后英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言
Sri Lanka	21.9	24.8	18.32%	4.01208	4.54336	25%	6.2	0.05%	0.01		英语作为STEM课程教学语言	英语作为STEM课程教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言
Zambia	21.3	38	16.02%	3.41226	6.0876	40%	15.2	0.92%	0.20	5年级开始英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言
Uganda	51.3	85.4	44.73%	22.94649	38.19942	60%	51.24	0.00%	0.00	5年级（城市地区1年级）开始英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言
Cameroon	30.6	51	37.99%	11.62494	19.3749	50%	25.5	0.00%	0.00	仅英语地区省份，英语作为4年级开始英语作为主要教学语言	仅英语地区省份，英语作为4年级开始英语作为主要教学语言	仅英语地区省份，英语作为4年级开始英语作为主要教学语言	仅英语地区省份，英语作为4年级开始英语作为主要教学语言
South Africa	63	79	50.00%	31.5	39.5	60%	47.4	8.73%	5.50		英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言
Botswana	2.52	3.4	38.42%	0.968184	1.30628	50%	1.7	0.00%	0.00	5年级开始英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言
Malawi	22.2	35	3.88%	0.86136	1.358	15%	5.25	0.01%	0.00	主要教学语言	主要教学语言	主要教学语言	主要教学语言
Zimbabwe	17.3	25.8	82.07%	14.19811	21.17406	90%	23.22	3.50%	0.61	4年级开始英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言
Lesotho	2.38	2.9	27.86%	0.663068	0.80794	40%	1.16	0.00%	0.00	4年级开始英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言
Guyana	0.8	0.9	90.55%	0.7244	0.81495	90.55%	0.81495	0.00%	0.00	主要教学语言	主要教学语言	主要教学语言	主要教学语言
Trinidad and Tobago	1.4	1.4	87.74%	1.22836	1.22836	90%	1.26	0.00%	0.00	主要教学语言	主要教学语言	主要教学语言	主要教学语言
Gambia	2.82	4.3	2.34%	0.065988	0.10062	10%	0.43	0.00%	0.00	4年级开始英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言
Liberia	5.7	6.7	82.67%	4.71219	5.53889	90%	6.03	16.00%	0.91	主要教学语言	主要教学语言	主要教学语言	主要教学语言
Namibia	3	4.5	17.24%	0.5172	0.7758	30%	1.35	0.77%	0.02	4年级开始英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言
South Sudan	12	18.3	35.00%	4.2	6.405	50%	9.15	7.50%	0.90	4年级开始英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言	英语作为主要教学语言
Papua New Guinea	11	21	30.00%	3.3	6	50%	10.5	1.00%	0.11	英文作为教学语言			
总计	2715.12	3440.8		676.18113	918.90716		1365.14495		36.41503				

(3) The Expanding Circle (the EU and Beyond)

The so-called expanding-circle countries are those never colonised by Britain or America. In these countries English is learned as a foreign language, but with the deepening of economic globalisation, English penetration among their populations keeps rising. The most prominent of the expanding circle is the European Union. According to the EU's 2024 statistics (see below^{[6][7]}):

ALMOST HALF OF EUROPEANS CAN HAVE A CONVERSATION IN ENGLISH AS A FOREIGN LANGUAGE, 5% MORE THAN IN 2012.

■ ALL EUROPEANS ■ EUROPEAN YOUTH (15-24 YEAR OLDS)



知乎 @最最遥远的路

The EU keeps expanding — Turkey, Serbia, Georgia, and others are all applying to join. The chart below shows the English-speaking population statistics and projections for the EU and the countries applying to join it. Since English penetration is relatively low in applicant countries like Turkey and Ukraine, these countries are expected to reach 323 million English speakers by 2050, about 54% of their total population of 594 million.

说明：人口单位是百万。

国家	人口(百万)	2050年人口(预计)	英语人口比例(当前值)	英语人口(当前)	英语人口(2050, 不考虑英语普及率提高)	英语人口比例(2050, 预测值)	英语人口(2050, 考虑英语普及率提高)
Albania	2.4	2.3	40.00%	0.96	0.92	55%	1.265
Armenia	3.1	2.4	4.93%	0.15283	0.11832	30%	0.72
Austria	9.2	9.4	73.08%	6.72336	6.86952	85%	7.99
Belgium	12	12	59.05%	7.086	7.086	65%	7.8
Bosnia and Herzegovina	3.1	2.5	57.00%	1.767	1.425	60%	1.5
Bulgaria	6.4	4.5	24.90%	1.5936	1.1205	50%	2.25
Croatia	3.85	3.2	39.66%	1.52691	1.26912	60%	1.92
Cyprus	1.4	1.5	72.56%	1.01584	1.0884	80%	1.2
Czech Republic	10.9	9.8	50.65%	5.52085	4.9637	65%	6.37
Denmark	6	6.3	86.05%	5.163	5.42115	90%	5.67
Estonia	1.4	1	47.03%	0.65842	0.4703	60%	0.6
Finland	5.6	5.6	70.09%	3.92504	3.92504	90%	5.04
France	68.6	70	57.25%	39.2735	40.075	65%	45.5
Georgia	3.8	3.4	52.00%	1.976	1.768	80%	2.72
Germany	83	83	55.74%	46.2642	46.2642	65%	53.95
Greece	9.9	9	50.98%	5.04702	4.5882	55%	4.95
Hungary	9.5	8.5	25.29%	2.40255	2.14965	35.00%	2.975
Iceland	0.4	0.4	98.00%	0.392	0.392	98%	0.392
Italy	59	54.7	13.62%	8.0358	7.45014	40%	21.88
Latvia	1.8	1.5	45.89%	0.82602	0.68535	70%	1.05
Lithuania	2.7	2.1	31.09%	0.83943	0.65289	50%	1.05
Luxembourg	0.7	0.8	25.67%	0.17969	0.20536	60%	0.48
Malta	0.5	0.5	88.48%	0.4424	0.4424	95%	0.475
Moldova	2.4	2.1	90%	2.16	1.89	90%	1.89
Montenegro	0.6	0.5	37.97%	0.22782	0.18985	50%	0.25
Netherlands	18.1	20	90.94%	16.46014	18.188	95%	19
North Macedonia	1.81	1.51	54%	0.9774	0.8154	60%	0.906
Norway	5.6	6.2	87.60%	4.9056	5.4312	95%	5.89
Poland	36.5	32.8	49.95%	18.23175	16.3836	60%	19.68
Portugal	10.2	9.8	27.30%	2.7846	2.6754	50%	4.9
Romania	18.7	16	30.98%	5.79326	4.9568	50%	8
Serbia	6.5	5.2	50%	3.25	2.6	60%	3.12
Slovakia	5.4	4.9	25.69%	1.38726	1.25881	40%	1.96
Slovenia	2.1	2	59.02%	1.23942	1.1804	70%	1.4
Spain	49	50	22.04%	10.7996	11.02	30%	15
Sweden	10.6	11.8	89.00%	9.434	10.502	95%	11.21
Switzerland	9.1	10.4	38.66%	3.51806	4.0342	50%	5.2
Turkey	86	95	14.96%	12.8656	14.22	30%	38
Ukraine	37	32	10.00%	3.7	3.2	30%	9.6
总计	604.86	594.61		239.50597	237.87734		323.753

(4) The Expanding Circle (the Middle East and North Africa)

In the Middle East and North Africa, although Arabic is the common language, the Arabic dialects differ greatly, and Arabic lacks a developed centre of cultural output; the result is that in this region English may become the common language of business, higher education, and science and technology. Especially in the Gulf (Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Kuwait, etc.), which employs large numbers of expatriate workers from India, Pakistan, and the Philippines, English has in fact become the lingua franca of daily communication.

Since the Middle East and North Africa are in the midst of industrialisation and deeply integrated into globalisation, they must use English in communicating with the people of nearby regions such as South Asia, Europe, and East Africa; English education in the region is therefore bound to develop rapidly.

As shown below, by 2050 these countries (Turkey not counted, being in the EU+ group) will have a total population of 759 million, of whom the English-speaking population is expected to reach 212 million, about 28%.

说明：人口单位是百万。

国家	人口（百万）	2050年人口（预计）	英语人口比例（当前值）	英语人口（当前）	英语人口（2050，不考虑英语普及率提高）	英语人口比例（2050，保守预测值）	英语人口（2050，考虑英语普及率提高）	小学教学语言中英语地位	初中教学语言中英语地位	高中教学语言中英语地位	高等教育教学语言中英语地位
Algeria	46.9	60	7.00%	3.283	4.2	20%	12				正在切换英语作为STEM课程教学语言
Egypt	116	150	35.00%	40.6	52.5	45%	67.5	国际学校（8%的学生）英语作为教学语言	国际学校（7%的学生）英语作为教学语言	国际学校（13%的学生）英语作为教学语言	英语作为STEM课程教学语言
Libya	7.4	8.1	0.00%	0	0	10%	0.81				英语作为STEM课程教学语言
Morocco	38.3	42	18.43%	7.05869	7.7406	40%	16.8				正在切换英语作为STEM课程教学语言
Sudan	51.6	60	10.00%	5.16	6	15%	9				
Tunisia	12.3	13.1	10.00%	1.23	1.31	30%	3.93				
Bahrain	1.55	2.1	60.00%	0.93	1.26	70%	1.47				英语作为主要教学语言
Iran	92.4	101	1.00%	0.924	1.01	10%	10.1				
Iraq	46.5	72	10.00%	4.65	7.2	20%	14.4				正在推广英语作为STEM课程教学语言
Israel	10	15	84.97%	8.497	12.7455	85%	12.75				
Jordan	11.5	14.2	45.00%	5.175	6.39	50%	7.1				英语作为STEM课程教学语言
Kuwait	5	6.1	60.00%	3	3.66	70%	4.27	私立学校（40%的学生）英语作为教学语言			英语作为STEM课程教学语言
Lebanon	5.8	5.3	39.99%	2.31942	2.11947	50%	2.65	部分学校（50%的学生）英语作为教学语言			英语作为优选的STEM课程教学语言
Oman	5.4	6	10.00%	0.54	0.6	50%	3	私立学校（13%的学生）英语作为教学语言			英语作为STEM课程教学语言
Palestine	5.6	9.5	15.00%	0.84	1.425	30%	2.85	私立学校（11%的学生）英语或法语作为教学语言			英语作为STEM课程教学语言
Qatar	3.1	3.8	70.00%	2.17	2.66	90%	3.42	部分学校（52%的学生）英语作为教学语言			英语作为STEM课程教学语言
Saudi Arabia	37	47	15.00%	5.55	7.05	30%	14.1	部分学校（15%的学生）英语作为教学语言或STEM教学语言			英语作为STEM课程教学语言
Syria	25.6	31.2	10.00%	2.56	3.12	15%	4.68				
United Arab Emirates	11.2	15	90.00%	10.08	13.5	90.00%	13.5	英语作为STEM课程教学语言			英语作为教学语言
Yemen	41.1	60	5.00%	2.055	3	7.00%	4.2				
Djibouti	1.18	1.31	5.00%	0.059	0.0655	10%	0.131				
Somalia	19.3	37	2.00%	0.386	0.74	10%	3.7				
总计	594.73	759.71		107.06711	138.29607		212.361		英语作为STEM课程教学语言		英语作为STEM课程教学语言

(5) The Expanding Circle (Others)

Other expanding-circle countries, such as China in East Asia, are not very active in promoting English education, and as China rises, the position of English there is even less certain. In other regions, such as Latin America, English penetration has always progressed slowly. And in the francophone countries of West Africa, during industrialisation the principal language remains French or a major indigenous language; English penetration must wait until French or the indigenous dominant language has completed its spread.

A few countries, however, are vigorously promoting English — Vietnam (for details see: How Should We View Vietnam's Policy of Making English the Foundation of the Nation?), Rwanda, Ethiopia, and others. In addition, the South Korean government is also pushing English-medium teaching in higher education — presumably both to attract international students for revenue and to solve its own high-skilled labour problem, laying a foundation for an English-speaking work environment by having domestic and international students attend English-taught courses together.

Below are the projections of the English-speaking populations of these countries in 2050. By 2050, the total population of these countries will be 422 million, with about 118 million English speakers. As for the other expanding-circle countries, since there are no government-promoted English teaching programmes, or the efforts are weak, the future position of English in them is uncertain, and other foreign languages (such as Chinese) might replace it. Hence there is no need to analyse the other expanding-circle countries for now.

国家	人口 (百万)	2050年人口 (预计)	英语人口比例 (当前值)	英语人口 (当前)	英语人口 (2050, 不考虑英语普及率提高)	英语人口比例 (2050, 保守预测值)	英语人口 (2050, 考虑英语普及率提高)	国家英语地位	小学教学语言中英语地位	初中教学语言中英语地位	高中教学语言中英语地位	高等教育教学语言中英语地位
Nepal	29.6	33	0.35%	0.1036	0	15%	4.95	非官方语言	私立学校和部分公立学校 (总体占比20%以上, 首都80%) 使用英语作为教学语言			英语作为STEM课程或部分商业课程教学语言
Vietnam	101.6	110	5.00%	5.08	6	20%	22	第二语言	2045年前英语作为第二语言 (STEM教学语言)			
Ethiopia	132	210	10.00%	13.2	21	30%	63	非官方语言	9年级开始使用英文作为教学语言			英文作为教学语言
Rwanda	14.1	22	21.24%	2.99484	5	40%	8.8	官方语言	4年级开始使用英文作为教学语言			
South Korea	51.67	47.3	20.00%	10.334	9	40%	18.92	非官方语言	2025年前英语作为第二语言 (STEM教学语言)			
总计	328.97	422.3		31.71244	41		117.67					同时吸引30万国际学生

(6) Summary

By 2050, the total population of the countries analysed above — where English effectively enjoys a status above that of a mere foreign language — will reach 5.758 billion (59.4% of the world population of 9.7 billion), and the English-speaking population is expected to reach 2.559 billion (26.4% of the world population).

类别	总人口 (2050) 单位 百万	英语人口 (2050, 按照当前的英语人口比例)	英语人口 (2050, 按照推测增长后的英语人口比例)
内圈	540.23	540.23	540.23
外圈	3440.8	918.90716	1365.14495
扩展圈 (欧盟+)	594.61	237.87734	323.753
扩展圈 (中东北非)	759.71	138.29607	212.361
扩展圈 (其他)	422.3	40.7283	67.67
总结	5757.65	1876.05887	2559.15895

II. English's Position as the Common Language

(1) Comparison with Other Potential International Lingua Francas

At present, the languages with the conditions to contend for the position of international lingua franca are: English, Spanish, French, Arabic, Chinese, and Russian.

On Spanish and French, I analysed in an earlier answer (Which Has the Brightest Future: French, Spanish, Russian, or Arabic?), the key content of which is excerpted below:

Spanish speakers in Latin America currently number over 400 million, rising to 500 million by 2050. Most of Latin America's population peaks before 2050, after which it slowly declines. Adding Spain's roughly 50 million, the peak population of the Spanish-speaking countries is about 550 million. However, Spanish and Portuguese are very close kin; Portuguese speakers can basically understand Spanish, and learning each other's language is easy. By 2050, the population of the Portuguese-speaking countries will reach about 350 million, and at least 400 million by 2100. Hence by 2050, the Portuguese + Spanish population will reach about 900 million, and may be maintained around that

level before 2100. The francophone countries of Africa will reach 325 million in 2050 and about 700 million in 2100; even if fertility falls more than expected, the francophone African population will be at least 600 million; adding France and Belgium, the world's francophone population will reach at least 700 million — higher than the Spanish-speaking population, but lower than Spanish + Portuguese.

The Spanish/Portuguese-speaking and French-speaking populations fall far short of the English-speaking countries. Even if every person in these countries mastered the common language, the total would still be at most 50% of the sum of English speakers in the inner- and outer-circle countries. Even considering mother-tongue speakers alone, English (500 million-plus) has no obvious disadvantage against Spanish, Portuguese, or French. At the same time, the francophone and Spanish/Portuguese-speaking countries are markedly weaker than the English-speaking countries in economic scale, industry, and science and technology; even by 2050 the English-speaking countries will still predominate. Hence French, Spanish, and Portuguese can hardly challenge English on any front; the probability of their replacing it is very low.

The Russian-speaking population is small (under 300 million) and shrinking. Meanwhile, Russia's share of the global economy is tiny and still falling, so the probability of Russian replacing English is virtually zero.

In the key region of the Middle East, English is basically universal in the Gulf states (GCC); Turkey, joining the EU, will also spread English; the main sources of the Middle East's migrants — Indians and Pakistanis — also speak English abroad; and the main destination of Middle Eastern capital later, East Africa, is also predominantly English-speaking. So Arabic will find it very hard to replace English in transnational communication and education. Arabic's disadvantage is that, in the age of globalisation, it lacks a developed country to champion it, with the result that English penetration in these countries keeps rising — and the higher the economic level, the higher the English penetration, especially in higher education. There is no sign of reversal before 2050. Although by 2050 the mother-tongue population of Arabic may reach about twice that of English, replacing English as the international lingua franca is basically impossible.

That leaves only one potential alternative: Chinese. In terms of mother-tongue population, Chinese is qualified to replace English. But Chinese is basically used only by the Chinese; very few people in other countries use it. Counting second- and third-language speakers, by 2050 the English-speaking population (2.559 billion) will be about double the Chinese-speaking population (1.3 billion). And the total population of the English-speaking countries (5.757 billion) will be more than four times China's population.

As for whether China, once risen, can rapidly spread Chinese education worldwide to replace English's position as the common language — this is theoretically conceivable, but practically there are no conditions for it.

China will fully obtain global hegemony no earlier than after 2035 — only fifteen years before 2050. In those fifteen years, to complete the switch of the global foreign-language teaching system so that the technical communication of scientists and engineers and the communication of commerce and trade across the world could all be conducted in Chinese — the probability is essentially zero. Just look at how difficult it has been for the francophone countries to switch to English-medium education to see that language switching is a long-term systematic project: first one must train teachers, and second, one must persist for at least twenty years before visible results. With English already the global lingua franca, completing such a switch is extremely difficult; unless China politically unifies the globe, it is impossible. Hence the probability of Chinese replacing English as the international lingua franca is also very low.

Some also bring up AI: won't AI translation make an international lingua franca unnecessary? For one thing, even with AI, people still need to communicate with each other — especially inside a multinational corporation; it is impossible for everyone to communicate entirely through AI translation. AI translation is only an aid; for long-term daily communication, one still needs to speak the same language. For another, by 2050, the total population of the countries where English is widely used will approach 60% of the world's population; even if the remaining 40% decide not to learn English, 60% of the world will still learn English and continue to use it in international communication — which in effect maintains English's position as the common language.

(2) Why English Can Retain Its Position as the International Lingua Franca

From the series of analyses above, one can see that the reason English can retain its position as the common language while China and other Southern countries rise one after another lies in three causes:

1. Britain's global colonisation produced a large group of countries with English as the official and educational language — the inner- and outer-circle countries discussed above. Their total population is 3.98 billion, and in 2050 they will reach 41% of the world's population. This population weight is the most fundamental basis of English as the international lingua franca.
2. America's post-war hegemony happened to coincide with the transition of capitalism into transnational production, so the process of economic globalisation was carried out through the medium of English. On this point, one only needs to look at the share of English in international organisations, multinational corporations, the IT open-source community, and academia.
3. Within 15–30 years after China's rise, a large group of countries in South Asia, the Middle East, and East Africa will complete their industrialisation — and these countries happen to be either former British colonies or deeply influenced by Britain and America. Especially in South Asia and East Africa, English has taken root in social life; replacing it would require China to colonise them

again, which everyone knows is impossible. If, after China's rise, South Asia had to wait fifty years or more to slowly complete industrialisation and urbanisation, then Chinese replacing English would have a certain possibility. But we know — although many Chinese wish for it — that the pace of economic globalisation will not stop at China, and the door of industrialisation cannot be welded shut by any country. See the column's articles: "The Rise of India," "The Capitalist Development of the Southern World," and "Observations on Southeast Asian Industry and Urbanisation."

III. The Significance of English's Position as the Common Language

Language is a key factor of national culture. The life-world of human beings is mediated by language: only people who speak the same language can regard one another as fellow beings. The spread of a national language was an important condition for the emergence of the nation-state. And the emergence and spread of an international language is the cultural foundation for humanity — first of all the proletariat — to transcend the nation-state and achieve the great unity of the world.

If English's position as the common language continues for another 20–30 years after 2050, then by that time around 30%–40% of the world's people will probably use English for communication (with varying proficiency, but basically able to communicate), and the share among the young may well reach over 60%. Communication between the peoples of different countries will increase greatly — not only tourism, food, and fun, but also intellectual and political exchange.

After 2050, as most advanced industrial countries enter deep ageing in succession, the transfer of industries and the movement of labour will both have to increase greatly. By then, multinational corporations' organisation of labour at the global level and the scale of workers' transnational movement will be far larger than today. Facing a world-system of capitalism in crisis, will the first truly self-conscious transnational proletariat in history emerge from the general communication among the peoples of all countries, opening a new chapter in human history? This is well worth looking forward to.

Notes

[1] "English the preferred language for world business: poll" (Reuters): The survey of 16,344 employed adults in 26 countries showed that 67 percent, or just over two-thirds, of workers who deal with people beyond their borders said English was the language used most often, with Spanish a very distant second at five percent.

中文原文：《English the preferred language for world business: poll》The survey of 16,344 employed adults in 26 countries showed that 67 percent, or just over two-thirds, of workers who deal with people beyond their borders said English was the

language used most often, with Spanish a very distant second at five percent.

<https://www.reuters.com/article/lifestyle/english-the-preferred-language-for-world-business-poll-idUSBRE84FoOW/>

[2] "Global Business Speaks English" (Harvard Business Review)

中文原文: 《Global Business Speaks English》

<https://hbr.org/2012/05/global-business-speaks-english>

[3] "The international companies using only English" (BBC Worklife)

中文原文: The international companies using only English

<https://www.bbc.com/worklife/article/20170317-the-international-companies-using-only-english>

[4] "Nigeria cancels mother-tongue teaching in primary schools and reverts to English" (BBC News)

中文原文: Nigeria cancels mother-tongue teaching in primary schools and reverts to English

<https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cd7rlrzq88wo>

[5] "Government push for English medium public schools sparks heated debate" (The Citizen, Tanzania)

中文原文: 《Government push for English medium public schools sparks heated debate》

<https://www.thecitizen.co.tz/tanzania/news/national/government-push-for-english-medium-public-schools-sparks-heated-debate-4831278>

[6] "Europeans and their languages" (Eurobarometer)

中文原文: Europeans and their languages

<https://europa.eu/eurobarometer/surveys/detail/2979>

[7] "Embrace 'bad English' as the European 'lingua franca,' says Timmermans" (Brussels Times)

中文原文: Embrace 'bad English' as the European 'lingua franca,' says Timmermans

<https://www.brusselstimes.com/509639/embrace-bad-english-as-the-european-lingua-franca-says-timmermans>

This article was originally published on Zhihu (in Chinese): <https://zhuanlan.zhihu.com/p/2013953379995510492> Author: 最最遥远的路 · Zhihu profile: <https://www.zhihu.com/people/zui-zui-yao-yuan-de-lu-32/posts>

本文原发表于知乎专栏/回答 (中文): <https://zhuanlan.zhihu.com/p/2013953379995510492>; 作者: 最最遥远的路: <https://www.zhihu.com/people/zui-zui-yao-yuan-de-lu-32/posts>